

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

MUNICIPALITIES - SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

MUNICIPALITIES - SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Subject: Indian Polity | **Topic:** 24

This workbook contains exactly 32 original MCQs before the verified PYQs. The correct-answer sequence is ABCD repeated eight times. Every option has a distinct explanation and every MCQ has a question-specific examiner trap.

The original-question key rotates strictly A -> B -> C -> D eight times. Every distractor is explained separately.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

The 74th Constitutional Amendment came into force on:

A. 1 June 1993. B. 24 April 1993. C. 26 January 1993. D. 20 April 1993.

Answer: A.

Option explanations

- A: Correct: Part IXA and the Twelfth Schedule commenced on 1 June 1993.
- B: This is the commencement date of the 73rd Amendment and Part IX.
- C: Republic Day is not the commencement date of the municipal amendment.
- D: Presidential assent occurred in April 1993, but commencement was later.

Examiner trap 1: Enactment, assent and commencement are separate legal dates.

MCQ 2

Part IXA of the Constitution extends from:

A. Articles 243 to 243O. B. Articles 243P to 243ZG. C. Articles 244 to 244A. D. Articles 243ZH to 243ZT.

Answer: B.

Option explanations

- A: This is Part IX on Panchayats.
- B: Correct: Articles 243P-243ZG form Part IXA on Municipalities.
- C: These provisions concern Scheduled and tribal areas.
- D: This is Part IXB on co-operative societies.

Examiner trap 2: Remember the sequence: IX Panchayats, IXA Municipalities, IXB Co-operatives.

MCQ 3

Which pairing is constitutionally correct?

A. Nagar Panchayat - larger urban area B. Municipal Council - transitional area C. Municipal Corporation - larger urban area D. Industrial township - fourth ordinary municipality

Answer: C.

Option explanations

- A: Nagar Panchayat is for a transitional area.
- B: Municipal Council is for a smaller urban area.
- C: Correct: Article 243Q associates a Corporation with a larger urban area.
- D: The industrial township is a notified exception, not an ordinary fourth type.

Examiner trap 3: Classification has three ordinary types plus a narrow proviso.

MCQ 4

Under Article 243Q, the Governor may specify an industrial township where:

A. the area is a census town. B. Parliament recommends municipal conversion. C. the population exceeds ten lakh. D. an industrial establishment provides or proposes municipal services and relevant factors justify notification.

Answer: D.

Option explanations

- A: Statistical classification alone does not trigger the proviso.
- B: Parliamentary recommendation is not the constitutional test.
- C: Ten lakh relates to metropolitan-area definition.
- D: Correct: the proviso turns on notified service provision plus size and other relevant factors.

Examiner trap 4: Every industrial area is not an industrial township.

MCQ 5

Article 243R requires direct election for:

A. territorial seats from wards. B. all experts represented in a municipality. C. every municipal chairperson nationally. D. all MPs and MLAs connected with the area.

Answer: A.

Option explanations

- A: Correct: territorial seats are filled by direct ward election.
- B: Experts may be represented but have no vote in municipal meetings.
- C: Chairperson election mode is left to State law.
- D: Specified legislators may be represented under State law; they are not directly elected as municipal ward members.

Examiner trap 5: The direct-election rule has a territorial-seat focus.

MCQ 6

Wards Committees are constitutionally mandatory in a municipality having population:

A. ten lakh or more. B. three lakh or more. C. one lakh or more. D. as fixed by the Union Government.

Answer: B.

Option explanations

- A: Ten lakh is the metropolitan-area threshold.
- B: Correct: Article 243S uses three lakh or more.
- C: One lakh is not the constitutional figure.
- D: State law designs committees, but the constitutional threshold is fixed.

Examiner trap 6: Three lakh attaches to the municipality, not each ward.

MCQ 7

The constitutional minimum reservation of directly elected municipal seats for women is:

A. one-fourth. B. exactly one-half. C. not less than one-third, including SC/ST women seats. D. left wholly to State discretion.

Answer: C.

Option explanations

- A: One-fourth is not the Article 243T floor.
- B: States may enhance the share, but one-half is not the national constitutional minimum.

- C: Correct: the one-third floor is inclusive of SC/ST women seats.
- D: State law implements the rule but cannot erase the constitutional floor.

Examiner trap 7: A minimum can be enhanced; it is not an exact nationwide percentage.

MCQ 8

Article 243T permits reservation for backward classes through:

A. an ECI order. B. a Union Finance Commission formula. C. a fixed constitutional 27 per cent quota. D. State legislation subject to constitutional and judicial controls.

Answer: D.

Option explanations

- A: The ECI does not design municipal reservation.
- B: Finance Commissions address fiscal matters, not electoral quotas.
- C: The Constitution sets no national 27 per cent municipal quota.
- D: Correct: clause (6) is enabling and judicial doctrine requires empirical safeguards.

Examiner trap 8: OBC reservation is enabled, not numerically fixed by Part IXA.

MCQ 9

A municipality ordinarily continues for five years from:

A. the date appointed for its first meeting. B. the date of result declaration. C. the Governor's assent to the municipal law. D. the first budget presentation.

Answer: A.

Option explanations

- A: Correct: Article 243U uses the first-meeting date.
- B: Result declaration does not start the constitutional duration.
- C: The general municipal statute's assent is unrelated to a body's term.
- D: Budget timing does not control constitutional duration.

Examiner trap 9: The clock begins at the appointed first meeting.

MCQ 10

If an early-dissolved municipality had less than six months of its term remaining:

A. a full five-year successor must be elected. B. an election need not be held for that short remainder. C. the ECI decides whether to hold an election. D. the State may postpone the next regular election indefinitely.

Answer: B.

Option explanations

- A: A successor after premature dissolution serves only the remainder.
- B: Correct: the proviso removes the need for a short-remainder election.
- C: The SEC, not ECI, administers municipal polls.
- D: The ordinary next cycle remains constitutionally controlled.

Examiner trap 10: The short-remainder exception is not a general postponement power.

MCQ 11

Which case is the principal authority for timely municipal elections?

A. K. Krishna Murthy. B. Vikas Kishanrao Gawali. C. Kishansing Tomar. D. Suresh Mahajan.

Answer: C.

Option explanations

- A: This case concerns local political reservation doctrine.
- B: This case states the OBC triple test.
- C: Correct: Kishansing Tomar treats the Article 243U timetable as mandatory.
- D: Suresh Mahajan rejects indefinite delay while reservation compliance remains unfinished.

Examiner trap 11: Match each case to its exact contribution.

MCQ 12

State of Goa v. Fouziya Imtiaz Shaikh chiefly protects:

A. property-tax autonomy. B. MPC supremacy. C. direct election of mayors. D. institutional independence of the State Election Commission.

Answer: D.

Option explanations

- A: The case is not a municipal taxation ruling.
- B: It does not elevate MPCs over State agencies.
- C: It creates no national mayoral-election rule.
- D: Correct: a serving government officer could not hold the SEC office.

Examiner trap 12: SEC independence is an institutional holding, not a complete election code.

MCQ 13

Article 243W is best described as:

A. an enabling State-law gateway for municipal powers and Twelfth Schedule responsibilities. B. an automatic transfer of all 18 matters. C. a Union executive power over municipalities. D. a municipal taxation article.

Answer: A.

Option explanations

- A: Correct: State legislation may endow powers and responsibilities.
- B: The Schedule does not self-execute activity transfer.
- C: Local government remains substantially State-mediated.
- D: Taxation and funds are addressed by Article 243X.

Examiner trap 13: The word 'may' is central to the devolution gap.

MCQ 14

The Twelfth Schedule contains:

A. 29 matters. B. 18 matters. C. 12 matters. D. 20 matters.

Answer: B.

Option explanations

- A: Twenty-nine belongs to the Eleventh Schedule.
- B: Correct: the municipal Schedule lists 18 matters.
- C: Twelve is not the constitutional total.
- D: Twenty is not the constitutional total.

Examiner trap 14: Municipalities = Twelfth Schedule = 18.

MCQ 15

Which is included in the Twelfth Schedule?

A. Police. B. Agriculture. C. Regulation of land use and construction of buildings. D. Inter-State trade.

Answer: C.

Option explanations

- A: Police is a State List function, not a listed municipal matter.
- B: Agriculture appears in the Panchayat-oriented Eleventh Schedule.
- C: Correct: land-use and building regulation is item 2.
- D: Inter-State trade is not a Twelfth Schedule item.

Examiner trap 15: Do not substitute broad State List subjects for the exact 18 matters.

MCQ 16

The best test of complete functional devolution is whether the municipality controls:

A. only the subject label. B. only a grant portal. C. only council meeting minutes. D. activities, staff, assets, budget and accountability for the service.

Answer: D.

Option explanations

- A: A label without activities permits overlap.
- B: Portal compliance does not transfer authority.
- C: Minutes record deliberation but not delivery control.
- D: Correct: devolution must cover the executable service chain.

Examiner trap 16: Functionality requires authority plus capacity and answerability.

MCQ 17

Article 243X permits State law to:

A. authorise municipal taxes, assignments, grants and funds. B. create a national uniform property-tax rate. C. directly issue Union grants to wards. D. replace the State Finance Commission.

Answer: A.

Option explanations

- A: Correct: these are the four fiscal routes in Article 243X.
- B: Property-tax design remains State and municipal-law specific.
- C: The Article does not create direct Union-to-ward transfers.
- D: The SFC has a separate Article 243Y role.

Examiner trap 17: Article 243X is enabling and State-law bounded.

MCQ 18

Which statement about property tax is most accurate?

A. It is imposed directly by Article 243X. B. It is a major potential own-source revenue whose base, valuation and collection depend on applicable law and administration. C. It is a Union tax assigned automatically to all municipalities. D. It can be replaced completely by municipal bonds.

Answer: B.

Option explanations

- A: The Constitution authorises State legislation; it does not itself levy the tax.

- B: Correct: legal design and administration determine yield and fairness.
- C: It is not an automatically assigned Union tax.
- D: Debt cannot replace recurring own revenue.

Examiner trap 18: Separate constitutional permission from the actual taxing statute.

MCQ 19

Municipal bond proceeds are:

A. tax devolution. B. grants-in-aid. C. borrowed capital carrying repayment obligations. D. SFC own-source revenue.

Answer: C.

Option explanations

- A: Devolution transfers revenue; it does not create debt.
- B: A grant does not require debt repayment.
- C: Correct: a bond is regulated borrowing.
- D: An SFC may discuss borrowing context, but the proceeds are not own-source tax revenue.

Examiner trap 19: Always show the liability side of bond finance.

MCQ 20

Article 280(3)(c) asks the Union Finance Commission to recommend:

A. municipal election dates. B. municipal chairperson reservations. C. direct municipal tax rates. D. measures to augment State Consolidated Funds to supplement municipal resources on the basis of SFC recommendations.

Answer: D.

Option explanations

- A: Election timing belongs to Articles 243U and 243ZA.
- B: Reservation belongs to Article 243T and State law.
- C: The UFC does not set local tax rates through this clause.
- D: Correct: the clause creates a State-mediated supplementation route.

Examiner trap 20: Union supplementation is linked to State funds and SFC recommendations.

MCQ 21

Article 243Z concerns:

A. State-law provision for municipal accounts and audit. B. the State Election Commission. C. industrial townships. D. metropolitan definition.

Answer: A.

Option explanations

- A: Correct: accounts and audit are left to State legislation.
- B: SEC elections are Article 243ZA.
- C: Industrial township appears in the Article 243Q proviso.
- D: Metropolitan area is defined in Article 243P.

Examiner trap 21: Z is audit; ZA is elections.

MCQ 22

The DPC elected-member floor is:

A. two-thirds. B. not less than four-fifths. C. exactly one-half. D. three-fourths.

Answer: B.

Option explanations

- A: Two-thirds belongs to the MPC.
- B: Correct: Article 243ZD uses not less than four-fifths.
- C: One-half is not the constitutional floor.
- D: Three-fourths is not the stated fraction.

Examiner trap 22: DPC 4/5; MPC 2/3.

MCQ 23

The MPC must prepare:

A. a municipal election roll. B. a State Finance Commission report. C. a draft development plan for the metropolitan area as a whole. D. a national urban policy.

Answer: C.

Option explanations

- A: Electoral rolls are under SEC control.
- B: SFC review is separate.
- C: Correct: metropolitan-wide draft planning is the Article 243ZE function.
- D: National policy is not the MPC's constitutional task.

Examiner trap 23: Planning committee does not mean election or finance commission.

MCQ 24

A metropolitan area under Article 243P requires:

A. three lakh or more only. B. a Municipal Corporation alone. C. a Union notification. D. ten lakh or more plus the notified multi-jurisdiction or contiguous-area character.

Answer: D.

Option explanations

- A: Three lakh is the Wards Committee threshold.
- B: A corporation can exist without satisfying the full metropolitan definition.
- C: The Governor specifies the area by public notification.
- D: Correct: both population and territorial composition matter.

Examiner trap 24: Ten lakh is necessary but not the complete definition.

MCQ 25

Article 243ZB provides for:

A. application of Part IXA to Union Territories with constitutional substitutions and possible Presidential modifications.
B. automatic exclusion of all Union Territories. C. application only to Delhi. D. extension to Scheduled Areas by State law.

Answer: A.

Option explanations

- A: Correct: the Article adapts Governor and Legislature references for UTs.
- B: Part IXA is not wholly excluded from UTs.

- C: The rule is general, though notifications may vary.
- D: Scheduled-area extension is a parliamentary route under Article 243ZC.

Examiner trap 25: UT adaptation and Scheduled-area extension are different provisions.

MCQ 26

Article 243ZC excludes in the first instance:

- A. all hill areas. B. Scheduled Areas under Article 244(1) and tribal areas under Article 244(2). C. every cantonment. D. all metropolitan areas.

Answer: B.

Option explanations

- A: The constitutional wording is narrower than all hill areas.
- B: Correct: these are the specified excluded areas.
- C: Cantonments are outside ordinary municipal form for statutory reasons, not this clause.
- D: Metropolitan areas are expressly planned under Article 243ZE.

Examiner trap 26: Use the exact Article 244 cross-reference.

MCQ 27

A Cantonment Board is best classified as:

- A. a Municipal Corporation under Article 243Q. B. an MPC committee. C. a statutory local authority under central cantonment law and Defence administration. D. a Smart City SPV.

Answer: C.

Option explanations

- A: It is not an Article 243Q corporation.
- B: It does not prepare the metropolitan draft plan.
- C: Correct: the Cantonments Act, 2006 supplies its legal basis.
- D: An SPV is a different corporate/programme vehicle.

Examiner trap 27: Similar civic functions do not erase distinct statutory identity.

MCQ 28

A Board of Major Port Authority is created under:

- A. Part IXA directly. B. a State municipal notification. C. the Cantonments Act, 2006. D. the Major Port Authorities Act, 2021.

Answer: D.

Option explanations

- A: Part IXA does not create port boards.
- B: Major ports use central statutory authority, not ordinary State municipal notification.
- C: Cantonment law is unrelated.
- D: Correct: the 2021 central Act supplies the statutory board.

Examiner trap 28: The old generic 'Port Trust' label must be updated to the current major-port statute.

MCQ 29

Which is constitutionally universal across India?

A. Direct election of territorial municipal seats. B. Direct election of every mayor. C. A five-year mayoral tenure. D. An executive mayor superior to the commissioner.

Answer: A.

Option explanations

- A: Correct: Article 243R secures direct ward-based territorial seats.
- B: Mayoral election varies by State.
- C: Mayoral tenure varies by State.
- D: Executive allocation varies by State law.

Examiner trap 29: Universalise only the constitutional floor, not a State model.

MCQ 30

A Smart Cities Mission SPV is:

A. a fourth municipal type. B. a dated programme vehicle that must be reconciled with elected municipal accountability. C. the constitutionally required MPC. D. the State Finance Commission.

Answer: B.

Option explanations

- A: Article 243Q has only three ordinary municipal types.
- B: Correct: an SPV is not a constitutional body.
- C: MPC is created by Article 243ZE.
- D: SFC is constituted under Article 243I.

Examiner trap 30: Project architecture is not constitutional devolution.

MCQ 31

Which reform best addresses parastatal fragmentation?

A. Transfer every regional utility regardless of scale. B. Abolish State standards. C. Define activity maps, council-approved outcomes, service agreements, shared data and asset/O&M responsibility. D. Replace elections with expert boards.

Answer: C.

Option explanations

- A: Scale economies may justify regional utilities.
- B: State standards can protect equity and quality.
- C: Correct: this aligns specialisation with democratic accountability.
- D: Expertise cannot substitute for elected legitimacy.

Examiner trap 31: The answer is accountable coordination, not indiscriminate abolition.

MCQ 32

The strongest qualified conclusion on municipal reform is:

A. constitutional status alone guarantees autonomy. B. grants alone create self-government. C. directly elected mayors alone solve urban governance. D. municipal empowerment requires aligned functions, functionaries, funds, planning and accountability, with coordination where scale demands it.

Answer: D.

Option explanations

- A: Articles 243W and 243X show why status alone is insufficient.

- B: Grants may deepen dependence if authority remains fragmented.
- C: Mayoral reform cannot cure finance, staff and planning gaps alone.
- D: Correct: the conclusion integrates subsidiarity with accountable coordination.

Examiner trap 32: Reject single-instrument cures.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS AND KEY DISCIPLINE

PYQ 1 - UPSC GS-II 2023, Q3

Exact verified wording

"The states in India seem reluctant to empower urban local bodies both functionally as well as financially." Comment. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand route

Directive -> exact constitutional hook -> operating gap -> named evidence -> qualification -> verdict.

Model answer

The 74th Amendment secured the constitutional existence of urban local bodies, but Articles 243W and 243X left substantial functional and fiscal empowerment to State law.

Functionally, the Twelfth Schedule lists 18 matters, yet activity-level control over land use, water, transport or housing often remains with development authorities, boards and State departments. The elected council can therefore face public blame without controlling staff, assets or implementation. DPCs and MPCs provide constitutional planning forums, but their budget and agency linkage varies.

Financially, Article 243X enables local taxes, assigned revenue, grants and funds, while Article 243Y requires SFC review. Weak property registers, uneven collection, delayed SFC follow-through and tied transfers constrain discretion. The Sixteenth Finance Commission's accounts, SFC and own-source-revenue conditions recognise these gaps.

The reluctance is not absolute: elections, reservation and stronger State examples show progress. However, States have devolved municipal form more consistently than municipal power. Complete empowerment requires activity maps, accountable staff control and predictable finance together.

PYQ 2 - UPSC GS-II 2024

Exact verified wording

Analyse the role of local bodies in providing good governance at local level and bring out the pros and cons merging the rural local bodies with the urban local bodies. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand route

Directive -> exact constitutional hook -> operating gap -> named evidence -> qualification -> verdict.

Model answer

Local bodies improve good governance by combining elected proximity, reservation, local planning, service feedback and a visible tax-service relationship. Their contribution becomes real only when functions, staff and money are aligned; otherwise parastatals and tied grants leave responsibility without capacity.

Merging a functionally urban rural body with a municipality can unify land-use, water, waste and mobility planning, reduce boundary disputes, create scale economies and open access to urban technical and fiscal systems. Article 243Q's Nagar Panchayat and Article 243ZD's DPC provide constitutional transition and coordination anchors.

Costs include diluted village representation, loss of Gram Sabha proximity, altered taxes and user charges, disruption of assets and records, and possible exclusion of informal or peripheral residents. A statistical census town also does not automatically become a municipality.

Therefore merger should follow published density, employment, contiguity, service and fiscal criteria, with consultation, protected representation, phased charges and clear transfer of staff, assets, liabilities and entitlements.

PYQ 3 - UPSC GS-II 2020, Q13

Exact verified wording

"The strength and sustenance of local institutions in India has shifted from their formative phase of Functions, Functionaries and Funds to the contemporary stage of Functionality." Highlight the critical challenges faced by local institutions in terms of their functionality in recent times. (15 marks, 250 words)

Demand route

Directive -> exact constitutional hook -> operating gap -> named evidence -> qualification -> verdict.

Model answer

Functions, functionaries and funds are institutional inputs; functionality exists only when a local body converts them into timely, equitable and accountable outcomes.

First, functions remain ambiguous. Article 243W is enabling, and a Twelfth Schedule subject may be nominally assigned while activity-level powers remain with a development authority, water board or State department. This produces duplication and blame shifting.

Second, functionaries may be deputed from State cadres without effective municipal control. Councils then cannot direct engineers, planners or health personnel who implement citizen-visible services.

Third, funds are often fragmented. Article 243X depends on State authorisation; weak property records and collection reduce own revenue; SFC recommendations may be delayed or incompletely acted upon; tied project grants may create assets without operation-and-maintenance finance.

Fourth, cross-cutting systems remain weak: accounts and audit, procurement, grievance redress, ward participation, climate-risk planning and service data. DPCs and MPCs may lack technical secretariats or linkage to departmental budgets. Mission SPVs can further divide authority.

Reform requires binding activity maps, staff-control protocols, professional municipal cadres, predictable SFC transfers, fair GIS-backed property taxation, audited accounts, public service standards and accountable coordination with regional utilities.

Regional agencies may still be necessary for scale. Functionality therefore means not indiscriminate transfer, but convergence of authority, capacity and answerability around measurable public outcomes.

PYQ 4 - UPSC Prelims 2024, GS-I, Set A Q74

Which of the following statements are correct about the Constitution of India?

1. Powers of the Municipalities are given in Part IX-A of the Constitution.
2. Emergency provisions are given in Part XVIII of the Constitution.
3. Provisions related to the amendment of the Constitution are given in Part XX of the Constitution.

A. 1 and 2 only B. 2 and 3 only C. 1 only D. 1, 2 and 3

Official-key discipline: the locally held final UPSC Set-A key records D. Part IXA concerns Municipalities, Part XVIII Emergency Provisions and Part XX constitutional amendment.

SIX ORIGINAL MAINS MODELS

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: The 74th Amendment constitutionalised municipalities, but not municipal devolution. Examine. (150 words)

Model answer

The 74th Amendment transformed municipalities from optional State creations into constitutionally protected institutions. Part IXA requires three municipal forms, direct ward elections, reservation, five-year duration, SEC elections, SFC review and DPC/MPC planning.

Yet devolution remains incomplete. Article 243W says State law may endow powers over the Twelfth Schedule's 18 matters; it does not transfer them automatically. Land use, water or transport may remain with parastatals, while municipal staff stay under State cadres. Article 243X similarly authorises only State-permitted taxes, assignments, grants and funds. Weak property-tax administration and delayed SFC action restrict discretion.

Thus, constitutionalisation secured democratic form and continuity, but not uniform control over functions, functionaries and funds. The qualification is State variation: some municipalities possess stronger authority. The reform test is whether the elected council controls executable activities, staff, assets and predictable finance while coordinating transparently with regional agencies.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Assess the constitutional logic and democratic cost of the industrial-township exception. (150 words)

Model answer

Article 243Q ordinarily requires a Nagar Panchayat, Municipal Council or Municipal Corporation according to the area's urban character. Its proviso permits the Governor to notify an urban area or part as an industrial township where an industrial establishment provides or proposes municipal services, considering size and other factors.

The logic is administrative: a large industrial establishment may already finance roads, water, sanitation and other services, so duplicating a municipality could be inefficient.

The democratic cost is that service provision is not identical to self-government. Residents may depend on an establishment whose management is not electorally answerable, while taxation, planning and grievance routes may be unclear.

The exception is therefore defensible only as a narrow, reasoned and reviewable notification. Transparent service standards, resident participation, grievance redress and coordination with surrounding municipalities are essential. It must never be treated as an automatic fourth municipal type for every industrial area.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Analyse municipal fiscal weakness and propose an equitable reform strategy. (250 words)

Model answer

Municipal fiscal weakness reflects both limited authority and weak administration. Article 243X permits State law to authorise local taxes and fees, assign State revenue, provide grants and create municipal funds. Article 243Y requires SFC review, while Article 280(3)(c) provides a Union Finance Commission supplementation route through State Consolidated Funds.

However, property registers may be incomplete, valuation opaque and collection uneven. User charges may neither recover costs nor protect poor households. SFCs can be delayed or weakly implemented, and tied grants restrict local choice. Small towns face narrow tax bases, while metropolitan infrastructure creates large capital and maintenance needs. Bonds remain unsuitable without audited accounts, predictable revenue and viable projects.

An equitable strategy should:

1. complete GIS-linked property registers with transparent valuation and appeals;
2. widen collection before indiscriminate rate increases;
3. use lifeline tariffs or cross-subsidy for essential water and sanitation;
4. constitute SFCs on time and publish action-taken memoranda;
5. provide formula-based equalisation for weak tax bases and higher service costs;

6. adopt double-entry accounts, asset registers and timely audit;
7. use pooled finance or bonds only for appraised capital assets with debt-service capacity.

The Sixteenth Finance Commission's dated accounts, SFC and own-revenue conditions can reinforce reform, but grants cannot substitute for State devolution. Fiscal autonomy requires local effort, intergovernmental equalisation and prudent borrowing together.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Why has the Metropolitan Planning Committee not automatically solved city-region fragmentation? Discuss. (250 words)

Model answer

Article 243ZE creates an MPC for every notified metropolitan area. At least two-thirds of its members must be elected by and from municipal elected members and Panchayat chairpersons in the municipal-Panchayat population ratio. It must consider local plans, common resources, coordinated spatial planning, Union-State priorities and likely investments before forwarding a draft metropolitan plan.

This design addresses a real city-region problem: labour markets, transport, water, waste and ecology cross municipal boundaries. Yet constitutional creation does not automatically supply executive control. State law determines the remaining composition and assigned functions. Development authorities, transport corporations, water boards and State departments may retain statutory powers, budgets, data and assets. The MPC may therefore prepare a plan that is not binding on the agencies that invest or regulate land.

Capacity also matters. Without a technical secretariat, common spatial data, public consultation and linkage to departmental and municipal budgets, the committee can become episodic. Political representation may be diluted if nominated or governmental actors dominate beyond the elected floor.

Reform should make the MPC plan the common spatial framework, require agencies to disclose conformity or reasons for deviation, align capital budgets, integrate climate and housing concerns, and publish progress. Regional utilities may remain, but they must operate under transparent metropolitan outcomes.

The MPC is the constitutional planning answer; it becomes the operational answer only when law, budgets, agencies and democratic scrutiny are connected.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Evaluate the mayor-commissioner design and propose a balanced model for urban executive accountability. (250 words)

Model answer

Part IXA constitutionalises municipal representation but does not prescribe one national urban executive. Article 243R leaves the chairperson's election method to State law; mayoral tenure, executive powers, commissioner appointment and staff control therefore vary.

The commissioner model offers professional continuity, procurement experience, technical coordination and a link to State departments. This is valuable where municipalities lack cadres or where regional infrastructure requires State support. The weakness arises when the elected mayor is publicly visible but lacks control over staff, contracts or implementation. Responsibility then points downward to voters while authority points upward to the State.

A purely strong-mayor response can also fail. Direct election does not guarantee council support, technical capacity, fiscal power or metropolitan coordination. Concentrated elected power needs checks.

A balanced model should include:

1. adequate and predictable mayoral tenure;
2. a statutory split between council policy/budget powers and professional administration;
3. council approval and standing-committee scrutiny of plans and major contracts;
4. transparent commissioner appointment, performance agreement, transfer and removal rules;
5. a professional municipal cadre accountable within the local chain;
6. public service standards, dashboards, audit and grievance redress;

7. conflict-resolution rules between mayor, council and commissioner.

State-wide standards and cadre mobility may remain necessary, but they should not erase local answerability. The objective is not politician versus bureaucrat; it is coherent authority, competence and democratic control.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Design a reform framework for inclusive and climate-resilient municipal governance. (250 words)

Model answer

Inclusive climate resilience must begin with municipal authority over the systems that produce urban risk. The Twelfth Schedule links land use, water, sanitation, public health, solid waste, urban forestry, slum improvement, poverty alleviation and amenities; fragmented treatment of these functions magnifies vulnerability.

The framework should operate at four scales.

Neighbourhood: activate Wards Committees where constitutionally required; create legally grounded area participation; publish heat, flood and service-risk maps; include informal settlements, migrants, women, disabled persons and peripheral wards in priority-setting.

Municipality: adopt risk-sensitive land-use plans, protect drainage and urban ecosystems, ensure water and sanitation service chains, build heat-health and emergency continuity plans, and maintain asset registers. Finance these through fair property taxation, equity-aware charges, predictable transfers and climate-screened capital budgets.

City-region: use DPCs and MPCs to coordinate watersheds, mobility, waste facilities, housing and peri-urban growth. Bind parastatals and SPVs to common outcomes, shared data and asset/O&M agreements.

Accountability: connect budgets to service standards, disclose procurement and emissions/resilience indicators, audit outcomes, and provide accessible grievance routes.

Named constitutional evidence is Article 243W with the Twelfth Schedule and Articles 243ZD-ZE. The qualification is institutional scale: regional utilities may be efficient, but they must remain democratically accountable. Resilience is achieved when planning, finance, inclusion and maintenance converge before disaster, not only through post-event projects.